

Step Two: Dynamics

In the second step we connect each dream image to a specific dynamic in our inner lives. We identify the parts of our inner self that appear as the images in the dream.

The reason for making this connection is a fundamental one: We need to figure out what is going on inside ourselves that is represented by the situation in the dream. If we could not tie the dream to specific events, feelings, or other dynamics in our lives, the dream would be pointless. It would be mere entertainment.

To perform this step, we go back to the beginning and deal with each image, one at a time. For each image ask: “What part of me is that? Where have I seen it functioning in my life lately? Where do I see that same trait in my personality? Who is it, inside me, who feels like that or behaves like that?” Then, write down each example you can think of in which that inner part of you has been expressing itself in your life.

By *inner dynamics* we mean anything that goes on inside you, any energy system that lives and acts from within you. It may be an emotional event, such as a surge of anger. It may be an inner conflict, an inner personality acting through you, a feeling, an attitude, a mood.

Suppose we are working with this dream in which the word *blue* came up. You write all your associations with that word, and the one that “clicks” for you is *depression*—bad mood, having “the blues.” Now, during the second step, you look for the “blue” quality inside you: “Where is that blue quality in me? Where am I blue? Where have I been depressed?” The answer may come to you: “I’ve been depressed at my job.” Questioning yourself in this way, you begin to see how this image relates to an actual part of you.

Often we are unaware that depression has seized us. We are so busy that we don’t have time to focus on what is going on inside. In another case, something very good could be developing inwardly—a new strength emerging, a wound being healed, a chronic fear evaporating—that we fail to appreciate. We have to ask ourselves: “What goes on *inside me* that this dream speaks of?” Then we wake up to the paths that our inner lives are

taking.

We must find that specific inner event at the deepest level of our lives. And we need to find *specific examples*. We are not finished with this step until we find actual examples from our lives that correspond to the events in the dream.

We also need to keep writing. There was an old tradition in the Christian Church that one had not prayed unless one's lips had moved. This idea expresses a psychological truth: Something *physical* has to happen. This is why it is so important that you write your examples down on paper. When you physically write those examples, the connections with your dream become clear and definite.

TAKING DREAMS INWARDLY

At this stage in dream work there is always a question whether the dream is commenting on one's *inner* life or on the external situation. We sometimes express it by asking if the dream is to be taken "inwardly."

Most dreams are representations of what goes on inside the dreamer. Dreams usually speak of the evolution of forces inside us, the conflicts of values and viewpoints there, the different unconscious energy systems that are trying to be heard, trying to find their way into our conscious lives.

The overall subject of our dreams is, ultimately, the inner process of individuation. Most dreams, in one way or another, are portrayals of our individual journeys toward wholeness. They show us the stages along the way—the adventures, obstacles, conflicts, and reconciliations that lead finally to a sense of the self. Every dream, in some way, either shows our effort to integrate some unconscious part of ourselves into consciousness or our resistance against the inner self, the ways we set up conflict with it rather than learn from it. This is the primary subject that our dreams are reporting on, and this is what we should look for in our dreams.

At first, many people find it difficult to think of a complete inner world, existing within us and paralleling the outer world; for some, it is hard to see that our dream lives are mostly concerned with the inner world. Our culture teaches us to focus on the external world, so we jump to the conclusion that our dreams are talking about something on the outside. This is a collective prejudice we suffer from: We spontaneously assume that only the *outer* world has any importance.

The true significance of the inner world becomes more clear when we begin to realize that almost everything we do, every reaction we have, every

decision we make, every relationship we form, ultimately results from our inner qualities and inner dynamics. Everything is controlled by the huge energy systems that propel us from within, that determine most of what we think and do.

If you take your dreams as a reflection of the unconscious dynamics within you, you are most likely to get to the heart of the matter; if, however, you apply the dream on the external level, it usually turns out to be superficial. It is on the inner level that you can change life-patterns most profoundly; it is at the inner level that your dream is usually aimed.

There *are* a few dreams—they appear once in a great while—that are directed at something *outside* the dreamer and don't have anything to do directly with the dreamer's inner life. Sometimes people dream of great battles or disasters just before a war breaks out. Sometimes a person dreams of something happening to a friend or relative who is a great distance away, and later discovers that the event actually took place in the other person's life. As a general rule, however, symbols in a dream turn out to apply to the dreamer's own interior life. So, that is the best assumption to work from.

I remember a patient who came to me with a dream in which his friend drove at a crazy speed and crashed into a building. He feared that the dream foretold a car accident; he wondered if he should warn his friend. I told him that it was most likely that the dream used the image of his friend to symbolize an inflation in his own life—a runaway compulsion or “power trip” or enthusiasm that was about to get out of control. In the meantime, as a precaution, I advised him not to go riding with his fast-driving friend.

As it turned out, our interpretation was correct. The dreamer got a new job, started feeling like a big man, lost his head, and got into something of a “power trip.” Fortunately, since the dream had warned him of it, he spotted the ego inflation and brought it under control before it became too obnoxious. As for the friend who was shown crashing his car in the dream—he is still driving around like a madman.

The best solution I have come up with, after years of wrestling with this issue, is this: Always begin by applying your dream inwardly. Start by assuming that your dream represents an inner dynamic, and work with it on that basis. Later, if it turns out that the dream does refer to an external situation, adjust your interpretation accordingly.

There are good reasons for taking this approach, the first being, as we have said, the simple fact that most dreams refer to something going on

inside the dreamer. It makes more sense to start off with that assumption, therefore; otherwise, you are liable to miss the main import of your dream.

Second, we have to compensate for our collective prejudice in favor of the external world. The only way we can do this is to force ourselves, in a disciplined way, to look for the inner meaning of the dream. As soon as we start to apply the dream to our external lives, we get lost in speculations about people we know and all the situations we are involved with; we never get back to exploring the real subject: the situation *inside* that is creating the situation outside.

Even when our dreams make some direct comment on an external situation, you may assume that there is an inner dynamic involved. In some way, your relationship to that external person or situation is being affected by some fantasy that has seized you, some inner attitude that dominates you, some belief or ideal in your inner mind.

It is fruitless to waste your time trying to understand an external situation unless you also identify the psychological patterns within you that affect it. And it is toward those patterns that your dreams usually point.

Still, people often get confused over this issue, because the unconscious has the habit of *borrowing* images from the external situation and using those images to symbolize something that is going on inside the dreamer. Your dream may borrow the image of your next-door neighbor, your spouse, or your parent and use that image to refer to something inside you.

For illustration, let us suppose that a man is extremely prejudiced and opinionated. One night he dreams and the image of his wife appears in the dream trying to argue him out of some of his attitudes. It happens that his wife is an open-minded person with a flexible, inquisitive intelligence who is interested in other people's viewpoints. In this case the dream is probably using his wife's image to tell him that he needs to be less opinionated, less defensive, and more open to new ideas. The capacity for this is identified with his inner feminine side, so his unconscious chooses his wife's image to represent it in the dream. By using his wife as a symbol, the dream tries to wake him up to possibility within himself.

The natural reaction is to think: "Since my wife is in this dream, it is obviously talking about my wife or about my relationship to my wife." It is a natural conclusion, but, in practice, it usually isn't so. The dream is most likely to use the image of the wife to represent a quality in the dreamer, a conflict in the dreamer, or something evolving in him that has little to do,

directly, with his external wife.

In this situation the dreamer has several things to understand: First, he needs to see that he has an *inner* wife, who is distinct from his outer wife and lives in the inner world and is a part of him. Then, he needs to stop blaming his physical wife for his conflicts with his inner wife—which turn out to be conflicts within himself. Finally, he needs to take his inner wife, his inner feminine, seriously. He needs to try to understand what part of himself she represents and what it is that she is trying to communicate to him.

This is probably the single most important principle in dream work—the one that determines whether you will find the wisdom in your dreams. We have to recognize that dreams are intricate tapestries of symbolism, and each image represents something going on within our own selves.

Sometimes the urge to take the image literally is overwhelming, especially if you are in conflict with the person who has appeared in your dream. We want to use the dream as an excuse to blame the external person or to congratulate ourselves on how right we are. But if we resist that temptation, and instead look for the quality inside ourselves that the dream speaks of in symbols, we learn amazing things about ourselves that we could never otherwise have seen.

CONNECTING IMAGES TO SPECIFIC CHARACTERISTICS

Probably the most immediate and practical way to connect a particular image to yourself is to ask what traits you have in common with the image: What are the main characteristics of the person in the dream? How would you describe his or her character and personality? Where do you find those same traits in you?

If the image is of an angry person, where do you find an angry quality in you? If it is happy-go-lucky, where do you find that same quality in yourself?

We all have a set of fundamental characteristics from which everything else in our personalities derive: These basics include our feelings, belief systems, attitudes, and patterns of behavior and the values we adhere to. All these traits show up in our dreams and can be identified if we look for them.

Every dream is a portrait of the dreamer. You may think of your dream as a mirror that reflects your inner character—the aspects of your personality of which you are not fully aware. Once we understand this, we can also see that every trait portrayed in our dreams has to exist in us, somewhere, regardless of whether we are aware of it or admit it. Whatever characteristics the dream

figures have, whatever behavior they engage in, is also true of the dreamer in some way.

By this, I don't mean that the trait or behavior shown in the dream is *literally* true of the dreamer exactly as it is portrayed in the dream. Dreams often speak in extremes: They try to compensate for our lack of awareness of a quality by picturing it in extreme, dramatic imagery.

For example, if there is a thief in your dream, it doesn't literally mean that you are a thief. The dream uses this dramatic image to get your attention and tell you that you need to wake up to something inside you. It may be that you have been dishonest with yourself in some way. If so, you need to be aware of it and deal with it. But the image of the thief may also mean that you have repressed some fine quality in yourself, figuratively "locked it out" of your life, and the only way it can get back into your life is to "break in" like a burglar.

Because we often repress the best parts of ourselves and think of them as "negative" qualities, some of the richest parts of the self—even the voice of God itself—can only partake in our lives by "stealing" our time, stealing our energy through compulsions and neurosis, and slipping into our lives in the unprotected places where our guard is down:

Of the times and seasons, brethren, you have no need that I write you. For yourselves know perfectly that the Day of the Lord cometh as a *thief in the night*. (Paul, to the Thessalonians)

Our egos divide the world into positive and negative, good and bad. Most aspects of our shadows, these qualities that we see as "negative," would in fact be valuable strengths if we made them conscious. Characteristics that look immoral, barbaric, or embarrassing to us are the "negative" side of a valuable energy, a capacity we could make use of. You will never find anything in the unconscious that will not be useful and good when it is made conscious and brought to the right level.

What part of you will be hidden behind this symbol, the thief? Perhaps a lively trickster, with all sorts of surprising talents. Perhaps a juvenile delinquent in you who has never been allowed to grow up and put his heroic urge into something useful and mature. Perhaps it is Dionysus, who has had to hide out in the unconscious because you have no natural place for his ecstatic and lyrical spirit in the midst of your purposive life.

Only you will be able to say what part of you is represented by this symbol if it appears in your dream—for it is your own unconscious that holds the clues. But you may be sure that if you give it its place, and hear what it has to say, it will be revealed as a valuable part of your inner self.

Curiously, people usually resist their good qualities even more emphatically than they resist facing their negative qualities. There may be a character in your dream who behaves in a noble and courageous way. Since that inner person is part of you, its qualities are also yours. So long as you are facing your negative and immature traits squarely, you also have a duty to acknowledge the fine qualities in yourself, and to live them consciously.

LOOKING AT BELIEFS, ATTITUDES, AND VALUES

Our dreams constantly speak to us of our beliefs and attitudes. They are of such crucial importance because they largely determine what we do, how we relate to people, and how we react to most situations. Most of us are not remotely aware of how much we are controlled by our beliefs, even less aware of how unconscious our attitude systems are.

No one decides what beliefs and attitudes he or she will start off with. We all begin our lives with a set of attitudes that are dictated to us by the world outside us—family, tribe, or society. Generally, we don't know we have them. If we are consciously aware of them as our beliefs, we assume that they are right; it rarely occurs to us to question them.

At a certain point our dreams begin to challenge them and point them out to us, for the process of inner growth demands that we examine consciously everything that motivates us. If you look at the belief systems floating around in your dreams, you may find a power-mad dictator, a great general, a saint, or a sage living in you, with a complete matching set of attitudes. When this image appears, you should ask: "What set of beliefs, what opinions, does this character function out of? Do I unconsciously hold that same opinion without realizing it?"

Napoleon would represent a particular set of beliefs, a point of view about the nature of reality. The image of Gandhi symbolizes a completely different attitude about life, people, and power. You may find both coexisting inside you.

A liberal young man who believed that he had no interest in worldly power but only in service to the poor had the following dream on the day he received his professional license.

Dream

When I walk to the place to keep my appointment, it turns out to be a used-car lot. I stand on the sidewalk. Suddenly Richard Nixon walks up. He seems to be a salesman. He slaps me on the back and says: "Alright! Let's see some enthusiasm! If you're going to be a real professional, you've got to start learning the basic tricks for manipulating people. Learn to think positive. Put on a suit, look the part, feel the part. Get out there and sell yourself. That's the way to success."

To the dreamer, this dream was extremely sarcastic, as dreams often can be. In his conscious attitudes he disliked politicians, people who grasped after worldly power or used "motivational techniques," euphemisms for manipulating people through the hard sell. But here, in his dream, he found that he not only had a hidden power drive, he also had a whole belief system living in secret within. In spite of himself, he secretly believed, or part of him believed, in "getting ahead," going after rather cheap versions of earthly power and using Madison Avenue hype and manipulative charm to get there.

There was no mystery about what this dream was saying. The dream figure obligingly detailed the attitudes he stood for, much to the dreamer's chagrin. Such a dream is embarrassing but also infinitely valuable to the dreamer. It is worth pure gold to know what you are *really* up to, underneath your professed ideals. The dream enables you to make a conscious, ethical choice—either accept the attitudes in your dreams, or renounce them; or, best of all, make an intelligent synthesis.

In practice, neither the conscious attitude of your ego nor the unconscious attitude of your inner self is the final answer. The attitude that is true to your character lies somewhere in between. In fact, if your unconscious attitude seems exaggerated, it usually means that the unconscious is compensating for an equally off-balance, exaggerated position in the ego.

This is one way you can tell when your ego has taken an extreme, off-center position that is not true to your actual character: You will find an exaggerated position in the unconscious, compensating your ego's position. The unconscious attitude is always off-center exactly to the same extent that the ego attitude is. As the ego attitude becomes more moderate, the unconscious attitude also relaxes toward the center.

In the case of this last dream, the dreamer was lost in glorious idealism. He took no thought for anything practical or for how he would make a living. The unconscious reacted by producing a compensatory attitude of pure, ravenous materialism. When he scaled his idealism down to something more

practical, he found his secret power drive took on a less exaggerated form.

Dreams also talk about our values: our feelings about what is good, desirable, beautiful, true, moral, or honorable. Ultimately our values are the qualities that we seek most in life, the standards that give our lives a sense of meaning. Our values express what is highest and most important to us.

We all have many value systems coexisting inside us, and all are in conflict with each other to some degree. My ego may feel that work alone is virtuous and that wasting time is immoral. But another part of me has a different set of values. It wants to go to parties and would be happiest on a tropical island. My ego may value thrift and practicality above all, but another part of me feels that I will just die unless I can buy an expensive new suit or a luxurious car.

I learned something about this in a powerful way from a short, insignificant-looking dream that I had years ago when I first began work as a psychologist.

Dream

I am stealing a newspaper from a vending machine. I suddenly wake up to what I am doing, and I feel guilty.

This was a situation in which my ego held to a certain set of values but I then discovered that quite another value system ruled somewhere else in me. On the conscious level, I don't believe in stealing—not even a newspaper, which in those times would have cost only five cents. Yet the dream was hurling in my face this accusation: “You are a crook! Part of you wants to steal!”

What could I do with this? I felt devastated and guilty about this dream. I tried to find where in my life I was unconsciously stealing. Finally it occurred to me to look more closely at the other details in the dream. What about the newspaper?

I mulled it over. What does the newspaper represent? To me, it represents collective platitudes, collective opinions, gossip, scandals raked up to serve as news, propaganda. I saw that I was stealing something of very low quality, at least in the view of my unconscious. The dream objected to *what* I was stealing as much as to the act itself.

Finally I made the connections: At that time I was just starting in my profession. I was very unsure of myself. I was looking in awe at authority figures and trying to fit into every group, every clique, that might give me

some feeling of belonging or of being “someone.” I listened to all the collective opinions, the collective platitudes, and the gossip around these people, and I repeated it. Sometimes I repeated it as though it were *my* information, *my* conclusions, *my* viewpoint.

I was “stealing” all this collective nonsense because I wasn’t thinking for myself: I was taking it from others, free of charge, and serving it up as though it were my own. I was not paying the price for having my own ideas and wouldn’t dare think for myself because I so desperately wanted to belong. It was in this sense that I was “stealing” a lot of junk that wasn’t worth having in the first place.

This is not an unusual kind of stealing: Most people do it at one time or another when they want to fit into a group. But my unconscious protested, and used this dream to throw cold water in my face. Psychologically, it woke me up.

This dream is a good example for showing that we need to do each step of dream work thoroughly. We need to work with every image and overlook no details. We don’t know which detail may provide the key that opens up the deepest meaning of the dream. I spent a full week wrestling with this dream before I had enough sense to ask myself what the symbol *newspaper* meant to me.

Behavior patterns are among the most important personal traits that show up in our dreams. Our behavior, like our values, comes from within. Most of the time we are not very aware of what we do, or why we do it. Our behavior is generated by the values that we serve, by those inner beliefs and attitudes that we have discussed. One of the best ways to discover what you really believe in, what value you are really serving, is to watch your own behavior.

For example, you may *think* that you believe in saving money. Most people say they do, if asked. But, in actual practice, if you spend your entire paycheck and never save a cent, that reveals a completely different set of beliefs controlling you, a different value system than the one you profess.

Dreams are wonderful reporters of our unconscious patterns of behavior. If I tend to be opinionated and combative, my dreams will eventually show me a dream figure who is combative. My dreams will give me an idea of how I must sound to other people. If I constantly say yes to everyone when I ought to say no, my dreams may show me someone who does that. And the messes that he gets into will bear an uncanny resemblance to the messes I regularly

find myself in.

So, when you see a pattern of behavior in a dream, look for it diligently in your personal daily life. Somewhere you will find it, and behind your behavior, you will find an attitude.

LOCATING INNER PERSONALITIES

A good way to connect to the inner parts of yourself is to think of each dream figure as an actual person living inside you. Think of each person in your dream as one of the autonomous personalities that coexist within your psyche and combine to make up your total self.

Then the question becomes: “Where have I seen this *person* at work in my life lately? Where in my life have I seen her (if she’s a woman) doing what she did in the dream? What part of me is it that feels like that, thinks like that, behaves like that?”

If she brings conflict in the dream, then try to find the part of your personality that is in conflict or rebellion. If she seeks relatedness and affection in the dream, look for the part of you that has been looking for friendship, loving, falling in love. If she pulls you out of the gutter, as did the Girl with the Sparkling Eyes in the dream that follows Step Three, then look in your life to see where some strength, some interest, some insight has pulled you out of the gutter recently. And there you find her at work in your life.

You may see, as you look at your dream person, that he or she is a manifestation of one of the basic personality structures, one of the primary energy systems, that make up the psyche. A woman in your dream may exactly fit the description of the shadow, if you are a woman, or fit the description of anima, if you are a man. This discovery will give you some added hints about where you can expect to find this inner person in action in your life.

But if a man, for example, finds that a dream-person is his anima, his work does not stop there. He has to find specifically where she is active in his life. He has to find the feelings he has felt, the flow of fantasy that has seized him, the mood he has been in, the encounter with the inner world—whatever it is that shows exactly what has been going on in his life that he associates with the soul-feminine.

It is a mistake to jump to conclusions and to call your inner person *anima* or *shadow* or one of these terms if you are not really sure. For every dream-person who fits clearly within one of the archetypes, there are many others

who don't: They are just persons in your dream. In that case, don't force them into a mold. Let them be who they are.

In order to find this dream-person inside yourself, a good place to begin is to make a description. Write out what kind of person you think this is, what the person's main characteristics and personality are, what the person wants and means to you. Then you can look for the part of your personality that matches the description.

If the person is intolerant and moralistic, you look for the part of your character that is intolerant or puritanical. There you will find your dream-person, living in you and through you.

Often your dream gives the person a name. If not, you can invent a name that seems to capture the person's character. Or you can use a descriptive name. If it is a masculine figure, it may be Brave Warrior, Wise Elder, Old Miser, Sneaky Crook, Juvenile Delinquent, Young Prince, Trickster, Tribal Brother. If this is a feminine figure you may find yourself calling her Wise Mother, Tyrant Mother, Earth Mother, Faithful Sister, My Lady Soul, Lady of the Sparkling Eyes. If she fits the mythical role, you may give her a mythical name: Helen, Iseult of the White Hands, Guinevere.

It is best if we get acquainted with our inner personalities *as persons in their own right* before we start putting distance between us and them by using psychological classifications and jargon. You will get much closer to your inner feminine if you know her as "Lady Ingrid," for example, and think of her as a special and interesting being who lives inside you, than if you call her "the anima" and turn her into a clinical abstraction.

Thus, if a feminine figure appears in a man's dream he should not start describing her from the standard texts on anima. He must allow her to describe herself and be the unique, individual being who came to visit him in his dream. He must allow her to have her individuality.

In the same way, when a woman finds a masculine figure in her dream, she should not jump to the conclusion that this is her animus, and start automatically applying all the doctrines that pertain to the animus. She should get close to this inner person, find out what his character and functions are, learn from him directly what information or qualities he has to offer and what his role is in her inner world.

IDENTIFYING OTHER INNER REALITIES

Of course, the images in dreams are not only the dream-people. There are also places, buildings, animals, colors, numbers, objects, and abstract

geometric symbols. Dreams present an infinite variety of images, and all of them are used to symbolize, in some way, the flow of your inner life.

In one way or another, you can always picture the dream image as something located inside yourself. For example, if it is a place, then it is a place inside you, and you can locate it. A place in a dream may represent a “place to stand” in a moral sense—an ethical position you need to take. A place like the Castle of the Holy Grail represents a level of spiritual consciousness and also a goal toward which your inner growth is moving you. A dream place may also represent an emotional environment, a set of circumstances, or a sphere of influence.

Remember our preoccupation with the blue room? The main association was an emotional environment. The ego was sitting in the midst of a blue feeling, a depression.

One of the most frequent uses of places in dreams is to show you whose “turf” you are on, whose influence you are under. So a good way to understand the significance of a place is to ask who it belongs to.

Ancient astrologers formed the practice of speaking symbolically of the “house” of Mars or the “house” of Saturn or some other planet. It meant that your psyche had fallen under that planetary influence: You were visiting in its house. When you enter into one of these symbolic houses, you enter a different psychological environment, a different field of energy.

In the same way, if you find yourself in the house of your maternal grandmother, you know that you are in the sphere of influence of the Great Mother. It means that, for better or for worse, you were under her spell on the evening when your dream was hatching in the unconscious. It may mean that you are on the verge of a great revelation of the Queen of Heaven. If you are lying in the gutter in front of her house, however, it more likely means that you are caught in the negative side of your mother complex—caught in passivity and dependency. Only the circumstances of your dream will tell you for sure what it means to be in the “house of the Mother.”

If the house belongs to you, it probably represents your *ego-house*—the field of consciousness of the ego, the world the ego builds up around itself, made up of what you know, what you think, what you believe, and the walls erected to protect you from the unconscious. If your house is invaded from the outside, it generally means that the ego’s world is being invaded by forces from the unconscious. You are being confronted, perhaps, with realities, values, and parts of your own self that you have managed to avoid until now.

If you find yourself in a country ruled by an evil sorcerer or a military dictator, it may mean that you are under the control of your power drive. If you ride through a blessed land ruled by an ancient and wise king or queen, the dream is giving you a foretaste of what life feels like when we live attuned to the archetypal self, aligned with the highest wisdom within ourselves.

What about animals? If it is an animal, you may think of it as an animal instinct or animal consciousness that lives somewhere inside you, buried in the deepest primordial, prehuman roots of the psyche. It is one of the energy systems from which you are constructed and has to be taken into account. It barks from time to time if it is neglected.

Just as people have characteristics that you can identify with, so do animals. Animals, like many other archetypal symbols, have both positive and negative connotations. Dogs are a good example. Dogs are pack animals, like wolves and coyotes. A dog in your dream could refer to the human tendency to “follow the pack,” to get so involved with groups and collectivity and “belonging” that we cease to develop as individuals or to have an inner life. For humans, we find, are also pack animals. It is a strong instinct in us, one that brings out both the best and the worst in human nature.

On the other hand, dogs are supremely loyal. The humble image of a dog in your dream may refer to a noble quality in you, a capacity for the deepest loyalty. Sometimes it is difficult to tell from a dream whether the positive or the negative connotation is to be taken. Sometimes the dog may be a warning, sometimes a powerful affirmation. Usually some very small detail in the dream will tell us which way to take the symbol.

Jung found that animals often represent primitive physical and instinctual energy systems within us. They may correspond to a physical need for food, rest, or exercise or a need for erotic or sensual experience. A fight with a threatening animal in a dream may signal a conflict between the needs of your deep, instinctual side and the “civilized” attitudes of your conscious mind.

When they appear in mythical form, animals may also represent the great archetypes or the highest stages of spiritual consciousness and development. The elephant represents, in Hindu symbolism, the highest manifestation of the true self, and the elephant sometimes appears in the dream of a Westerner with the same meaning. In my own dreams, the white cobra comes to me often as a manifestation of the self, of the highest consciousness within me.

The examples I have given you in the last few pages represent only a tiny sampling of the infinite opportunities you have for connecting your dream images accurately to your inner self and the dynamics of your inner life. There could never be enough space—in this book or any other book—to cover all the symbols that might arise and the various ways they might connect to your life. And if we tried to do that, we would only mislead. For, as I have been emphasizing so strongly, the real connections between your dream symbols and your inner life can only truly come out of you, out of the fertile soil of your own unconscious.

DREAM WORK ILLUSTRATION: THE GIRL WITH THE SPARKLING EYES

As an example of how we can do this step with an actual dream, I will now present another dream, together with the connections that could be made to the inner life of the dreamer.

This dream was brought to me by a college student, twenty-two years old at the time. He came for analysis when he was unable to continue college because of a severe neurosis. He had reached the point where he couldn't study or pass his exams, and he was in a state of despair.

This was the first dream in the analysis. It beautifully depicted the state he was in, showed us what inner systems were involved, and pointed him in the direction he needed to go. The dream predicted the dramatic healing of the neurosis, which took place almost immediately after he began doing inner work. He is one of those people who can't live without an inner life, but once he recognized this, everything changed rapidly. He finished his education and now leads an unusually full and useful life.

In honor of the manifestation of his anima who appears here, I call the dream the Dream of the Girl with the Sparkling Eyes.

The Dream of the Girl with the Sparkling Eyes

I was lying in the street in front of my grandmother's house. An auto came from behind containing my sister and her friend. I was afraid that the car would run over me, and I rolled toward the curb as quickly as I could. Then they were beside me. My sister asked me if I would like her to arrange a date for me with one of her other friends. She mentioned a couple of names. I couldn't decide. Then my sister was gone. Her friend asked me what I wanted to do about the date. I thought for a minute and then thought suddenly that possibly this girl would like to spend the evening with me. Just as I thought this, I remembered that I hadn't really noticed what she looked like. I asked

her for a date just as she was walking away with her back turned. She turned around and I was happy to discover that she was attractive. She was THE GIRL WITH THE SPARKLING EYES. I asked her if she would talk with me, and she agreed. As she returned to me, I got up out of the gutter and walked away with her.

For purposes of the exercise with this dream, we have to assume that we have already been through the first step and made our associations, and some of them have “clicked.” Now, in the second step, we have to apply those associations to specific dynamics in the inner life of this college student. Here are the connections that he could have made:*

Second Step: What part of me, or what dynamic in my inner life, does each dream image refer to?

My grandmother’s house

Since it is my maternal grandmother, and my mother was born there, this must be the “house of the Mother” inside me. It goes back generations, so it is perhaps more than just mother complex; it is the archetypal mother, the mother energy or mother presence inside my psyche. This is her territory, so it says that “I”—the ego—am in her territory. The ego is caught in the territory of the Great Mother, and in some way I am under her influence.

Now, where have I seen this functioning in my everyday life? There is a side of the mother principle, a regressive relationship that I can get into with it, where I start acting like a child who can’t do anything for himself and just wants the world to take care of him. I feel dependent, I don’t want to make decisions, I don’t want to do anything for myself, and I just want someone to “mother” me. On this negative side, the mother energy has turned into a dependency complex. This is what I have seen in myself lately. I’ve given up my native masculinity, I’m afraid to venture out into the world and make my own way, I feel like I’m enveloped in the feminine side of myself, but in a negative way that makes me feel childlike and dependent.

Lying in the street

Where has this been going on in my life? I see it immediately. I have been depressed, in despair, unable to function at school, paralyzed, not knowing which way to turn. The image is an exact symbol of how I feel: like someone lying in the gutter, unable to get up, helpless. I feel that anyone can come along and take a kick at me or run over me. I have no defenses and I

can't help myself.

Another association that clicked is that this is a *public thoroughfare*. It is not my own space; it belongs to "them," out there. It seems that I am not only lost in the maternal feminine, I am also lost in collectivity. What do I find in my life that corresponds to that association? As I think about it, I realize that I have been revolving completely around what I think other people want me to do, or expect out of me. My going to college, the courses I took, the career plans, have basically come from some collective expectations that I assumed I had to live up to. I don't know whether they came from my family, from the society around me, or wherever—it scarcely matters. The point is that I have to start looking for the way of life that belongs to me, decide what values I want to serve, decide what is important to me, and start making my own decisions.

I think the only way I can get out of the street is to find the little plot of ground that really belongs to me, and stand there. I have to give up lying in the street and just stupidly accepting whatever collective notions come to me from the society around me.

My sister

If my sister in the dream represents a *person* living inside me, where is that inner person? Where do I have a feminine personality that is like my sister? One thing that "clicks" with me about my external sister is that whenever I am in a mood or depression she will act like this person in the dream. She tries to cheer me up, tries to draw me out of myself, tries to get me connected to the human race. Now that I look for it, I see that I have a feeling inside of me of wanting to connect up with people, wanting to find a friend I could be very close to. I don't want to be lonely.

Yet, I act just the way I act with the "sister" in the dream. I refuse to have anything to do with people; I act like a loner, preoccupied with my depression and my problems. I refuse relatedness. In the dream this is symbolized by my being unable to make a decision when she offers to set up a date. Maybe I don't want to get into dates, at this point, because I'm waiting for the Girl with the Sparkling Eyes, and don't know it. So I think my sister is the feminine force inside me that wants to draw me into relatedness with other people and with human life. But I can't seem to respond to that yet, because first I need to find my soul.

The girl with the sparkling eyes

I think of my ideal of the eternal feminine, the feminine presence I long

for, as the “girl with the sparkling eyes.” She feels somehow divine to me, like a princess or a goddess. When I see her, when I feel she is in my life, then I feel as though I am complete, as though I have something to live for, as though life has meaning. So she fits the description of the anima. She symbolizes my soul. This is the aspect of the feminine that, unlike the “sister,” leads me toward the *inner* world, toward the spiritual world, toward inner experience and religious consciousness. She, my anima or soul, is the feminine presence inside me who wants an experience of God, who wants to explore the unconscious, wants to live in the world of dreams and archetypes.

The amazing thing is that, as soon as I see who she is in the dream, I come out of my paralysis. I get up and I can walk. I start to live and function again.

Where do I see all this going on in my life? First, I have felt, in a manner of speaking, my soul longing for a different level of life. I came here, and started to learn how to look at my dreams, because I sense that there is an empty spot in me. I feel the need for an inner life, I feel an inner void, I want religious meaning, religious experience, or something that will give me a sense of the underlying meaning of my life. All of that going on inside me seems to be *her* presence: It is the Girl with the Sparkling Eyes, my soul, at work in me. These are her feelings that I am feeling. I have fantasies of a new, spiritual life, of delving deep into the mysteries of the unconscious. These must be *her* fantasies, coming out through my mind.

I asked her if she would talk with me

I asked her for a date, but it feels like the real turning point is when I ask her if she will talk with me. I am trying to set up a simple conversation, but it feels like the beginning of an exchange, a relationship.

Where do I find this going on inside me? As esoteric as it sounds, I think I am trying to find my soul, I am trying to set up a relationship to my own soul. Perhaps, in the moment that I decided I would write down my dream, and begin to look at dreams, start to live in the inner world—that was the moment when I said to my soul that I wanted to talk with her, that I wanted to get connected with my inner psyche and begin a friendship.

I got up out of the gutter

I can associate *getting up out of the gutter* with a very specific change inside me. As soon as I started understanding a little bit of this dream, and started wanting to have an inner life, I started feeling better. I don’t feel as helpless now. I don’t feel paralyzed and at the mercy of the world. I feel that

there is something that I can do to get life going again, to understand what is going on inside me. Opening up the inner world means that hope and life force returns to me; I don't have to lie in the gutter in passivity and paralysis.

Our dreamer was able to connect his dream experience to some very specific things going on in his emotional life. The dream was amazingly on point for much of what he was feeling and experiencing. He felt absolutely helpless and defeated by life at that time. The dream showed this vividly with the image of his lying in the street, completely passive, utterly at the mercy of passersby.

This dream gives us a good example of a way in which archetypal amplification becomes helpful. In this case, it provides us with a lot of information about the anima, so that we can see where she is at work in his life. Once we see that the Girl with the Sparkling Eyes is a soul-figure, a manifestation of anima, we can surmise several things. We know that anima leads us toward the inner world, that she is primarily concerned with the inner life. From this we can see that the meeting with this special person and the beginning of a relationship with her coincides with his decision to go to the inner world, through his dreams, to renew his inner life. This is, after all, the most direct way of going to anima and making relationship with her.